

# **The Holy Prophet of Islam (PBUH) and the Environment**

## **In the Name of God, the Compassionate, the Merciful**

There are two main aspects to the current argument:

1. The benefits of interreligious dialogue on the environment
2. A study of the Holy Prophet's (PBUH) views regarding a number of significant environmental problems

### **1. Benefits of Interreligious dialogue for the Environment**

The environment is an extremely important subject on which to have interreligious dialogue. This is due to the great benefits such dialogues could have. Let us examine a number of these benefits in the coming sections.

#### **1.1. Strengthening the convergence of religions**

If we accept that the common grounds between religions on the issue of environment are fundamental and influential, and that these common grounds are based on the tangible realities of life and nature, then we can conclude that expressing and emphasizing these common grounds may be effective in enhancement of the convergence and harmony between religions.

#### **1.2. Reinforcing the public motivation across societies to protect the environment**

Publicizing the common grounds shared by all religions on the issue of environmental problems in addition to analyzing and expounding them for societies could add a spiritual and religious aspect to the duty of protecting the environment. Indeed, the interference of religions into the issue of environment generates increased motivation in everyone to protect the environment.

#### **1.3. The fulfillment of religious faith depends on ensuring environmental health**

Essentially, if we fail to protect and conserve the environment, it is not only the environment that will be endangered; the spiritual life of all human beings may also be damaged as a consequence. In other words, there is a strong connection and interdependence between the two living environments of mankind: the material, and the spiritual environments. According to the logic of heavenly faiths, the material and spiritual environments are completely intermingled. It is, therefore, not possible to excel spiritually when the material environment ceases to function properly. A dilapidated environment, increasing pollutions of all types, and

disappearance of the beauty and exuberance of nature, undermine the chances of mankind to focus on spirituality, to reflect on God Almighty, or to even avoid and survive social deviances.

By the same token, it is not possible to keep the environment clean, vivacious and life-giving in absence of spirituality and morality. Therefore, spirituality and materiality, as the two essential elements that constitute man, have a close interrelationship with – and deeply affect – one another.

The more environment-related dialogues are initiated by religious leaders and theologians and the more positive outcomes result from such dialogues, the greater their success will be in their sacred mission to serve all humanity. From another standpoint, having dialogues on the environment not only supports the efforts to protect the environment itself, it is also sure to bring all religions closer to one another. Helping create a healthy environment and reinforcing the unity among religions may be the greatest service religious leaders could do humanity. Furthermore, as most global issues today revolve around the subject of environment, the harmony between religions and a common stance toward various issues could, in a way, also help alleviate other grave problems as well.

## **2. A study of the Holy Prophet's (PBUH) views regarding a number of significant environmental problems**

What we shall present in this article comprise three environmental issues on which the views of the Holy Prophet of Islam and His religion. Clearly, discussions about the environment are far from limited to the points discussed here, and it is hoped that other important issues will be addressed in due time.

### **2.1. Environmental Balance**

Environmental balance is a key concept in the discussions revolving the environment, and it denotes that nature, and the system on which it is based, consist of components between which there are dynamic, interwoven relationships. These components are blessed with the same harmonious cycles which enable nature to support life on earth and guarantee the conditions required for its uninterrupted existence. Because environmental balance is, basically, what makes life possible on earth, any efforts to disrupt it may cause fundamental, irreparable damage to the immaculate system of environment. On this basis, it may be said that disrupting this balance is indeed a grave abnormality and a greatly unethical act.

The Holy Quran contains four important terms as regards environmental balance which are as follows:

- *Qadar*: precise measure  
“Indeed, we have created all things in precise measure” (Quran 53:49).

- **مقدار** (pronounced *Meqdar*): proportionate measure  
*"Every single thing in His plans has been designed in proportionate measure"* (Quran 13:8).
- **موزون** (pronounced *Mowzoon*): harmonious, balanced, suitable  
*"And the earth We have spread out, set thereon mountains firm and immovable, and produced therein all kinds of things in due balance."* (Quran 15:19).
- **ميزان** (pronounced *Meezan*): proportionate measure, due balance  
*"And the heavens He raised high and He set up everything in proportionate measure, in order that ye may not transgress due balance"* (Quran 55:7-8).

The last pair of Verses, in which the term *Meezan* is used, are particularly notable as they contain a double message: a piece of information and a piece of advice or warning, as it were. The first one instructs the reader that everything in this world has been set up *"in proportionate measure"* i.e. in a balanced way. The immediately following verse then advises, or warns, humans against *"transgressing"* i.e. destroying this delicate balance.

## 2.2. Nature belongs to all human beings

The notion that nature belongs to mankind is a major legal approach which, today, possesses a crucial role in the environmental rights and literature. This notion, in fact, defines a legal framework in which the ownership of nature by people, organizations and governments is not final nor absolute; no one, then, can manipulate or abuse nature in a way that destroys it and deprives future generations of its priceless resources.

This very idea, that nature belongs not to the current one but to all generations, has been mentioned both in the Holy Quran and in the words of the Holy Prophet (PBUH) in the form of an unbending principle. We read in the Quran that *"He out the earth for the people"* (Quran 55:10). According to credible interpretations, the word **اناام** (pronounced *Anaam*) in this verse refers to all human generations at the same time. The prophet, too, asserts that *"Humans share three things: water, fire [fuel], and grasslands."* If according to the Quran the earth belongs to all people, and if as the prophet says, water, fuel sources and grasslands are shared by everyone, then it is evidently clear that no generation is ever permitted to be negligent, profligate, or destructive toward the earth and its resources.

Were we to legalize this Quranic principle so as to use it as the basis of our cultural, social, and economic life, then we should say: policy-making, installing laws, and all legal verdicts revolving the issue of how to deal with nature must comply with the principle of 'Nature belongs to all human beings,' in order that any and all modifications to the environment that is sure to waste natural resources, on which human life gravely depends, must be prevented.

### 3. The place of animals in the circle of life

If we accept that animals are a part of nature, and that all parts of nature have a dynamic, balanced, interrelationship with one another, then the importance of animals will seem undeniable. One of the most widely discussed issues regarding the place of animals in the circle of life is the negative impact of extinction of animals on the environment. The examples of such regrettable, damaging extinctions are many and well known. In this section, we shall point to a number of these examples so as to provide a brief explanation as to the complex relationships between environmental phenomena and the way these relationships affect the environment.

- a) There are times when as a result of the extinction of a herbivorous animal, the plants which should be eaten by the said animal begin to proliferate excessively. Such a change is considered harmful to the environmental balance.
- b) As another example, certain animals are known to help the pollination of certain plants. The potential extinction of such animals naturally leads to the extinction of plants that depend on them to proliferate, and the extinction of the latter may have its own set of adverse effects on the environment.
- c) And then, there may be cases where the extinction of predator species in a jungle facilitates an exponential increase in number of their herbivorous prey species. This unwelcome population increase may be beyond the capacity of that particular jungle, cause gradual deforestation, and ultimately bring about the death of that jungle. With the destruction of the jungle, the herbivorous species inhabiting it may be forced to migrate from one region to another, a development that can cause even more environmental imbalances elsewhere.

As may be seen, there is a connection between the extinction of certain species and the gradual destruction of a whole jungle; there is a connection between the destruction of a jungle and forced migration of animals; and so on. Consequently, important questions arise: Do animals have a vital role in the circle of life and other environmental processes? Have religions paid due attention to the significant issue of 'wildlife conservation?' If so, in what tone and to what degree? The answer is that, there are numerous instances throughout most religious texts (sacred books and narratives) where killing and abusing animals are severely condemned and denounced, while some texts are so strict as to forbid man to even disrespect animals. On this subject, there is a Verse in the Holy Quran, mentioning and analyzing which may provide the answer to the questions above and clarify the stance of Islam regarding the conservation of environment and wildlife.

*"If one is forced by necessity [to eat dead meat, swine, and the like], not willfully craving nor transgressing limits, no sin shall be upon him"* (Quran 2:173). The key points here is, again,

forbidding 'transgression' and observing the 'limits.' It has been affirmed in the narrative that by transgression, God Almighty is referring to excessive hunting and killing of animals. Furthermore, the narrative makes it clear that this Verse addresses those who go to the desert, mountains, and the like, as it is only logical to assume that hunting cannot be done in urban areas. Here lies a crucial point which refers to the necessity of conserving the environment and wildlife.

To elaborate on this, let us consider the basic stems of the two key words (عاد and باغ) in the verse, namely بغى and عدوان, which mean *violation* and *transgression* respectively, and here have been used in relation with natural environments such as deserts, mountains, etc. Is it not logically expected that concepts such as violation and transgression be exclusively used in social contexts—that is, where the relationship between two or more individuals is concerned? Why, then, have the two words been used in relation with commonly non-human environments such as mountains? The answer is that the Verse intends to provoke the attention of human beings to violating and transgressing the wildlife. It is true that animals are essentially non-human, but hunting and killing them is an example of violation and transgression. In other words, violation against the life of animals inevitably leads to violation against that of mankind. Humans need the environment to supply their resources and guarantee their livelihood. Killing animals endangers the very environment humans so direly need to survive.

To expound this more precisely, it must be said that, presumably, the use of the abovementioned terms – violation and transgression – in addition to the narrative on the killing of animals, connote the existence of a 'right.' That is, where there is no right to violate, transgression becomes but meaningless. Therefore, another question would be: what right are we dealing with here? The answer is that there are three things to which this right may pertain. First, the right of animals to live; killing an animal would be regarded as violating this right. Second, the right of the environment; killing an animal is an act of transgression toward the environment as a whole. And Finally, the right of humans; killing animals endangers the environment and the latter, of course, provides the basis for human life and abusing it leads to considerable difficulties for all humans.

Whichever the case, what remains doubtless is that a right is a right indeed no matter the context—social, urban, natural, or otherwise. That is, when the right of humans to live is deemed inviolable in human societies, it is just as inviolable in the wild for animals and plants. One might dispute this by saying that these rights are reserved for humans, the environment and the wildlife in a hierarchical way. Even so, the Quranic Verse still addresses the environment and that is the key point.